

Joel Teply

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Dear Hiring Team,

I am applying for DFA's Sr. Director, AI (AI Business Lead) position. I am a Kansas native, a University of Kansas Computer Engineering graduate, and the co-founder of an AI and computer vision company where I have spent years working at the intersection of technology, product strategy, enterprise customers, and business outcomes.

What particularly interests me about this role is that DFA is not looking for someone simply to advocate for AI. You are looking for someone who can determine where AI is actually useful, prioritize investments, translate business problems into achievable initiatives, work effectively with technical teams, and carry those initiatives through adoption and measurable results. That has been a significant part of my career.

I co-founded Cambrian and served first as CEO and later CTO, while remaining deeply involved in engineering. I led product and technical strategy, customer discovery, hiring, sales, partnerships, licensing, integration, and delivery. We developed computer vision and machine learning technology for enterprise customers across retail, home improvement, and automotive, taking ideas from early feasibility through production deployment. Our technology was licensed by major companies, reached millions of users, and was deployed through applications, SDKs, web platforms, and enterprise integrations.

That experience taught me an important lesson about emerging technology: technical capability alone does not create business value. A successful initiative has to solve the right problem, have a realistic path to deployment, fit into the systems and processes around it, earn adoption from the people expected to use it, and produce an outcome worth the investment. Sometimes the right answer is sophisticated machine learning. Sometimes it is a simpler system. Being able to distinguish between the two is an important part of leading an AI portfolio responsibly.

I also bring unusually deep technical experience for a business-facing AI leadership role. I have designed and deployed machine learning and computer vision systems, production inference services, data pipelines, GPU workloads, cloud infrastructure, and distributed systems. My current work includes LLMs, agents, RAG, continual learning, LoRA, evaluation, model routing, quantization, and distributed inference and training. That depth allows me to work closely with architects and engineers, understand technical tradeoffs and risks, and challenge assumptions without confusing business ownership with architecture ownership.

As a founder, I have also spent much of my career translating between groups that naturally see problems differently. Customers describe business problems; engineers see systems and constraints; executives need priorities, cost, risk, and outcomes. Moving between those perspectives—turning an ambiguous opportunity into requirements, technical work, a deliverable product, and ultimately something customers will use—has been central to my work.

Responsible AI is part of that same discipline. As AI becomes embedded in enterprise decisions and workflows, evaluation, provenance, security, privacy, human oversight, monitoring, and clearly defined success criteria cannot be added after deployment. My recent work has placed particular emphasis on measurable evaluation, reproducibility, persistent model and system state, and gating learning or adaptation on demonstrated improvement. I would bring that engineering mindset to DFA's broader governance and risk framework while partnering closely with legal, compliance, IT, and business leadership.

I am especially interested in doing this work at DFA because it combines AI with a large, real-world enterprise where technology has to produce practical value. The opportunity to identify high-impact uses across the Cooperative, build a disciplined portfolio around them, and help move AI from experimentation into useful, governed capabilities is compelling to me.

There is also a personal connection to the location. I grew up in Kansas, earned my Computer Engineering degree at KU, and built my company and career in the Kansas City area. I would be excited to bring both the technical and business sides of that experience to DFA.

Thank you for your consideration. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss how DFA is building its enterprise AI capability and where you see the greatest opportunities for AI to create measurable value across the Cooperative.

Sincerely,

Joel Teply